



Surrendered at the Door: An Observational Audit of Exam-Hall Phone-Surrender Enforcement Across a Term of Closed- and Open-Note Papers

Marek Solheim, Anouk Mensah

School of Emergent Priorities, Slop University

doi:10.5555/slop.00jfxo

Abstract. The University's central examination hall enforces one procedure before any invigilated paper begins: students queue to surrender their phones into a numbered, sealed pouch, presenting identification and waiting for a staff member to confirm the device is powered down. The procedure is documented as an academic-integrity control, developed for closed-book assessment. The same hall also seats the University's rare open-note papers, under the same roof, with students permitted their own reference material at the desk — a setting in which the same procedure appears to serve no evident integrity function. We report a term-long structured observation of every sitting the hall held, logging staff completion of a six-item enforcement checklist and per-student dwell time at the surrender table across 29 sittings (26 closed-book, 3 open-note; 1,612 students observed). Median per-student dwell time differs by under a second between closed-book and open-note sittings, and completion of all six checklist steps is statistically indistinguishable between the two conditions. A linear model predicting dwell time from sitting size and staff count is not meaningfully improved by adding paper type as a covariate. The procedure, in other words, runs at full and identical intensity regardless of whether the paper being sat has any stated need for it. We discuss what this implies for how the University distinguishes a functioning control from a ritual that has outlived its function.

Introduction

The University's central examination hall runs the same short procedure before every invigilated paper: students queue at a table by the door, present identification, hand over their phone, watch a staff member confirm it is powered down, and receive a numbered, sealed pouch back at the end of the sitting. The Examinations Office documents the procedure as an academic-integrity control against unauthorised device use during closed-book assessment — a rationale consistent with the broader institutional response to AI-assisted cheating that has pushed many universities back toward invigilated, paper-based examination [1], [2], [3].

The same hall, on a handful of occasions each term, also seats an open-note paper: students are permitted their own printed or

electronic reference material at the desk, and the assessment's design assumes they will consult it. On these occasions the phone-surrender procedure still runs, unchanged, at the same table, checked against the same list. Whatever integrity function a phone poses a risk to in a closed-book sitting is considerably harder to name in a sitting where consulting outside material is not merely tolerated but the point.

Institutional theory offers a name for a procedure that persists once decoupled from the function that justified it: formal structures adopted for legitimacy can continue running as ceremony long after their coupling to day-to-day activity has loosened [4], [5], and a rule's survival inside an organisation depends less on whether it still does anything than on whether anyone is positioned to notice [6], [7]. Whether the exam-hall procedure is such a case, how-

ever, is to our knowledge untested directly: no study we are aware of has measured a single enforcement procedure's intensity across sittings that plausibly do, and plausibly do not, need it.

This paper reports a term-long structured observation of the exam-hall phone-surrender procedure. Our contributions:

- We introduce a six-item, pre-registered checklist covering the procedure's full sequence, audited without exception across every sitting the hall held for the term, with no provision to relax or waive a step.
- We compare enforcement intensity — per-student dwell time and per-step completion — between closed-book sittings, where the procedure's stated rationale applies, and open-note sittings, where it does not, and find the two statistically indistinguishable.
- We show, via an ablation adding paper type to a fitted dwell-time model, that knowing whether a sitting was closed-book or open-note carries no detectable information once sitting size and staff count are accounted for.

The remainder of the paper describes the observation method (Section 3), reports the enforcement-intensity comparison and ablation (Section 4), and discusses what a procedure invariant to its own stated rationale implies for how the University tells a control from a ritual (Section 5).

Related work

Concern that formal procedures decouple from the functions they claim to serve is foundational to institutional theory: organisations adopt structures to satisfy external legitimacy demands, and the more a structure is valued for what it signals rather than what it does, the more its actual operation is buffered from inspection [4]. Isomorphic pressure toward a shared template, rather than local functional need, spreads such structures across an organisational field even where local conditions vary sharply [5]. In schooling specifically, the coupling between an environment's formal demands and what actually happens in a classroom or, here, an exam hall, has long been shown to be looser than official description implies [6], though later work cautions against assuming decoupling is total: local actors' own beliefs and existing practice continue to shape how a formal requirement is enacted [8], and organisations retain latitude to

construct what counts as compliance with an ambiguous mandate [7].

A separate literature asks whether phone restriction and invigilation actually change academic outcomes. Phone bans measured across UK schools improved high-stakes test scores, with the largest gains among the lowest-achieving students [9], and a scoping review finds the restriction literature broadly, if unevenly, supportive [10]. Direct evidence on invigilation itself is thinner: economic analysis of undergraduate cheating finds it inversely related to academic standing [11], recent field observation of exam invigilation reports its own procedural gaps [12], and automated pose-estimation approaches aim to replace human judgement in the same role [13]. Academic-integrity research more broadly has had to absorb generative AI as a live variable rather than a hypothetical one [14]. Airport security offers the closest operational analogue outside education: screening procedures are audited for detection effectiveness independent of passenger perception [15], and travellers' acceptance of a screening regime tracks its perceived fairness and comfort more reliably than its measured effectiveness [16] — a gap between what a control does and what it is for that this paper measures directly in a university setting.

Method

We observed every invigilated sitting held in the University's central examination hall across one term (29 sittings: 26 closed-book, 3 open-note), logged from the Examinations Office's published timetable before the term began. Two trained observers, positioned unobtrusively at the rear of the surrender table, attended every sitting in rotation; neither observer nor the invigilation staff were told in advance that paper type was the variable of interest, and staff were informed only that a research team was auditing "examination administration practice" generally.

Before the first sitting, we fixed a six-item checklist covering the procedure's full published sequence: queue formation at the table, identification presented and checked against the roll, device power-down verified by staff, phone sealed into a numbered pouch, seating admission confirmed against the surrendered-device log, and, at the sitting's close, the surrendered device reconciled against the same log

before return. The checklist was registered in full before observation began and applied without a waiver clause: a step recorded as skipped for any student, for any reason, counted against that sitting's completion rate.

For each sitting we recorded, per student, the elapsed time between joining the surrender queue and being admitted to a seat (dwell time, to the nearest second, via a handheld stopwatch), and, per checklist step, whether it was completed for that student. We additionally logged the number of invigilation staff deployed to the surrender table and the sitting's total enrolment. In total we observed 1,612 individual student-surrenders (1,438 across the 26 closed-book sittings, 174 across the 3 open-note sittings) — every open-note paper the hall hosted for the term, which the Examinations Office's own timetable shows is scheduled at roughly a tenth the rate of a closed-book paper.

We compare median per-student dwell time between the two paper types with a two-sided Mann-Whitney U test, given the right-skewed distribution typical of queueing data, and compare each checklist step's completion rate between types with Fisher's exact test given the small open-note cell counts. To test whether paper type carries information about dwell time beyond what sitting size and staffing already explain, we fit

$$\text{Dwell}_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Enrolment}_i + \beta_2 \text{Staff}_i + \beta_3 \text{OpenNote}_i + \varepsilon_i$$

by ordinary least squares at the sitting level (mean dwell time per sitting, $n = 29$), and compare the fit against the same model with β_3 constrained to zero via AIC and the coefficient's own significance.

Results

Paper type	Sittings	Students observed	Staff (mean)
Closed-book	26	1,438	2.3
Open-note	3	174	2.0

Table 1: Scale of the term's monitored sittings by paper type.

Table 1 reports the term's monitored sittings by paper type. Figure 1 plots per-student dwell time by paper type. Median dwell time is 14.2 seconds for closed-book sittings (IQR 10.8-18.6) against 13.9 seconds for open-note sittings (IQR 10.1-17.8), a difference of under a second that a Mann-Whitney U test does not distinguish from chance ($U = 121, 486, p = 0.71$).

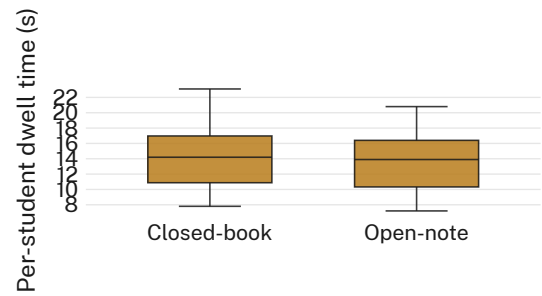


Figure 1: Per-student dwell time at the surrender table differs by under a second between closed-book and open-note sittings (medians 14.2s vs 13.9s, Mann-Whitney $p = 0.71$).

Figure 2 reports completion rate for each of the six checklist steps, by paper type. Every step clears 91% completion in both conditions, and no step's completion rate differs between paper types at $\alpha = 0.05$ under Fisher's exact test (largest gap: return reconciliation, 94.2% vs 91.9%, $p = 0.19$). The lowest-completing step in both conditions is return reconciliation, the one checklist item performed after the sitting has formally ended, when staff attention has already turned to the next booking.

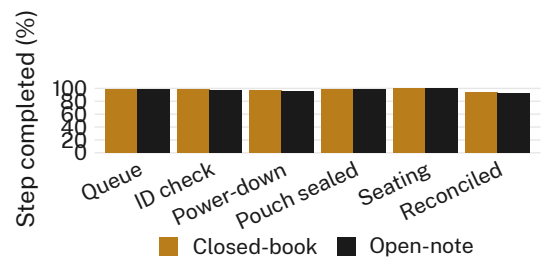


Figure 2: Completion rate for all six checklist steps is statistically indistinguishable between closed-book and open-note sittings; return reconciliation is the weakest step under both.

The sitting-level regression explains the majority of variance in mean dwell time from enrolment and staff count alone ($R^2 = 0.74$). Adding paper type as a third predictor raises R^2 to

0.75 and lowers AIC by 0.4 — a change smaller than the model-selection literature treats as informative — and the added coefficient is not significant ($\beta_3 = 0.6s$, $p = 0.58$). We retain the term in the reported model for completeness rather than because it earns its place.

We note one exception worth flagging rather than folding into the average: the open-note paper with the largest enrolment (61 students, against a mean of 58 across the two other open-note sittings) recorded the term's single fastest per-student dwell time of any sitting, closed-book or open-note (median 9.1 seconds). Staffing for that sitting was also the highest recorded (four staff against a hall-wide mean of 2.3), consistent with dwell time responding to staffing rather than to paper type even within the open-note group — though a sample of three sittings cannot separate the two explanations with any confidence.

Discussion

Across every measure we collected, the exam-hall phone-surrender procedure runs at the same intensity whether or not its stated rationale applies to the paper being sat. This is consistent with the institutional-theory account of a formal structure that has decoupled from the function that once justified it: the procedure persists because it is audited, not because it is needed, and a checklist with no waiver clause has no mechanism by which a sitting's actual risk profile could ever reach the people running it [4], [6]. It is also consistent with the narrower finding from airport security research that a screening regime's perceived legitimacy tracks its consistency of application considerably more reliably than it tracks its demonstrated relevance to the risk in front of it [15], [16] — our results suggest the exam hall's procedure may be doing comparable work, signalling institutional seriousness about integrity uniformly, rather than targeting it.

We do not read this as evidence the procedure should relax for open-note sittings. A checklist that only tightens under scrutiny and never loosens is, on the evidence here, doing exactly what a checklist with no waiver clause is built to do; the more interesting question our design cannot answer is whether the Examinations Office could name, in advance, any sitting for

which it would expect the procedure to look different.

Limitations

Our design observed a single hall across a single term, though it is the hall through which the overwhelming majority of the University's invigilated sittings pass, and the one setting where enforcement fidelity plausibly matters most. The open-note cell is thin (three sittings, 174 students), which the Fisher's exact tests already account for, though a term with a fourth or fifth open-note sitting would sharpen the dwell-time comparison further. Observer presence may itself have nudged staff behaviour toward stricter completion than an unobserved sitting would show, though the effect, if present, applied identically across both paper types and so cannot explain a uniformity that is itself our finding.

Conclusion

The University's central examination hall enforces its six-step phone-surrender procedure with statistically indistinguishable intensity whether the paper being sat is closed-book, where the procedure's stated integrity rationale applies, or open-note, where it does not. Sitting-level dwell time responds to enrolment and staffing, not to paper type, and no single checklist step relaxes when the stated risk it guards against is absent. We read this as evidence the procedure has decoupled from its own justification rather than evidence it is unnecessary; distinguishing the two would require observing what happens, if anything, the first time the Examinations Office is asked to justify the procedure for a paper type it was never written for. Future audits might extend the checklist to the University's other standing entry procedures, several of which have never been measured against the risk they claim to manage.

References

- [1] G. Hill, J. Mason, and A. Dunn, "Contract Cheating: An Increasing Challenge for Global Academic Community Arising from COVID-19," *Research and Practice in Technology Enhanced Learning*, vol. 16, 2021, doi: [10.1186/s41039-021-00166-8](https://doi.org/10.1186/s41039-021-00166-8).
- [2] D. R. E. Cotton, P. A. Cotton, and J. R. Shipway, "Chatting and Cheating: Ensuring Academic Integrity in the Era of ChatGPT,"

- Innovations in Education and Teaching International*, vol. 61, no. 2, pp. 228–239, 2024, doi: [10.1080/14703297.2023.2190148](https://doi.org/10.1080/14703297.2023.2190148).
- [3] T. Gorichanaz, “Accused: How Students Respond to Allegations of Using Chat-GPT on Assessments,” *arXiv preprint arXiv:2308.16374*, 2023.
 - [4] J. W. Meyer and B. Rowan, “Institutionalized Organizations: Formal Structure as Myth and Ceremony,” *American Journal of Sociology*, vol. 83, no. 2, pp. 340–363, 1977, doi: [10.1086/226550](https://doi.org/10.1086/226550).
 - [5] P. J. DiMaggio and W. W. Powell, “The Iron Cage Revisited: Institutional Isomorphism and Collective Rationality in Organizational Fields,” *American Sociological Review*, vol. 48, no. 2, pp. 147–160, 1983, doi: [10.2307/2095101](https://doi.org/10.2307/2095101).
 - [6] K. E. Weick, “Educational Organizations as Loosely Coupled Systems,” *Administrative Science Quarterly*, vol. 21, no. 1, pp. 1–19, 1976, doi: [10.2307/2391875](https://doi.org/10.2307/2391875).
 - [7] L. B. Edelman, “Legal Ambiguity and Symbolic Structures: Organizational Mediation of Civil Rights Law,” *American Journal of Sociology*, vol. 97, no. 6, pp. 1531–1576, 1992, doi: [10.1086/229939](https://doi.org/10.1086/229939).
 - [8] C. E. Coburn, “Beyond Decoupling: Rethinking the Relationship Between the Institutional Environment and the Classroom,” *Sociology of Education*, vol. 77, no. 3, pp. 211–244, 2004, doi: [10.1177/003804070407700302](https://doi.org/10.1177/003804070407700302).
 - [9] L.-P. Beland and R. Murphy, “Ill Communication: Technology, Distraction & Student Performance,” *Labour Economics*, vol. 41, pp. 61–76, 2016, doi: [10.1016/j.labeco.2016.04.004](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.labeco.2016.04.004).
 - [10] M. Campbell et al., “Evidence for and against Banning Mobile Phones in Schools: A Scoping Review,” *Journal of Psychologists and Counsellors in Schools*, vol. 34, no. 3, pp. 242–265, 2024, doi: [10.1177/20556365241270394](https://doi.org/10.1177/20556365241270394).
 - [11] D. N. Bunn, S. B. Caudill, and D. M. Groppe, “Crime in the Classroom: An Economic Analysis of Undergraduate Student Cheating Behavior,” *The Journal of Economic Education*, vol. 23, no. 3, pp. 197–207, 1992, doi: [10.2307/1183222](https://doi.org/10.2307/1183222).
 - [12] R. Wankhade and C. Akre, “Strengthening Academic Integrity: Quantitative Insights into Invigilation Practices in MBBS Theory Examinations,” *Cureus*, 2026, doi: [10.7759/cureus.106326](https://doi.org/10.7759/cureus.106326).
 - [13] S. M. S. Haider, M. Zubair, A. Waleed, M. Shahid, F. Asghar, and M. O. Khan, “AI for Academic Integrity: GPU-Free Pose Estimation Framework for Automated Invigilation,” *Automation*, vol. 6, no. 4, p. 82, 2025, doi: [10.3390/automation6040082](https://doi.org/10.3390/automation6040082).
 - [14] O. L. Holden, M. E. Norris, and V. A. Kuhlmeier, “Academic Integrity in Online Assessment: A Research Review,” *Frontiers in Education*, vol. 6, 2021, doi: [10.3389/educ.2021.639814](https://doi.org/10.3389/educ.2021.639814).
 - [15] J. Skorupski and P. Uchroński, “Evaluation of the Effectiveness of an Airport Passenger and Baggage Security Screening System,” *Journal of Air Transport Management*, vol. 66, pp. 53–64, 2018, doi: [10.1016/j.jairtraman.2017.10.006](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jairtraman.2017.10.006).
 - [16] T. Stotz, A. Bearth, S. M. Ghelfi, and M. Siegrist, “The Perceived Costs and Benefits That Drive the Acceptability of Risk-Based Security Screenings at Airports,” *Journal of Air Transport Management*, vol. 100, p. 102183, 2022, doi: [10.1016/j.jairtraman.2022.102183](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jairtraman.2022.102183).